CARSI

Cleaning & Restoration Sciences Institute · IICRC CEC Accredited provider

How to Get on Government Restoration Panels

A practical guide for Australian restoration contractors

About This Guide

Government restoration work represents some of the most reliable, high-value contracts available to Australian restoration companies. State and federal agencies manage thousands of buildings — schools, hospitals, courthouses, defence facilities, public housing — all of which require restoration services when water damage, mould, fire, or storms strike.

Getting onto a government panel means predictable revenue, professional credibility, and a competitive moat that smaller operators struggle to cross.

This guide walks you through the requirements, certifications, and application process for pursuing government restoration panel positions across Australia.

Chapter 1: Understanding Government Procurement

How Government Panels Work

Government agencies at all levels (federal, state, and local) use **standing offer arrangements** (also called panels, registers, or approved supplier lists) to pre-qualify contractors. When restoration work is needed, the agency contacts panel members directly — bypassing the open-tender process entirely.

Why panels matter:

- **Faster engagement** — No need to compete for every individual job
- **Predictable pipeline** — Panel members receive work on rotation or by capability
- **Established rates** — Panel rates are agreed up front through the procurement process, rather than renegotiated job by job
- **Payment reliability** — Government agencies pay on agreed terms (typically 30 days)

Key Procurement Platforms

Platform	Level	URL	Use
AusTender	Federal	austender.gov.au	Commonwealth government tenders and panels
NSW eTendering	State (NSW)	tenders.nsw.gov.au	NSW government procurement
Buying for Victoria	State (VIC)	buying.vic.gov.au	Victorian government procurement
QLD QTenders	State (QLD)	qtenders.epw.qld.gov.au	Queensland government procurement
WA Tenders	State (WA)	tenders.wa.gov.au	Western Australian procurement
SA Tenders	State (SA)	satenders.sa.gov.au	South Australian procurement
TAS eTender	State (TAS)	purchasing.tas.gov.au	Tasmanian government procurement
VendorPanel	Multi-level	vendorpanel.com	Used by many local councils and state agencies
Local council websites	Local	Varies	Individual council procurement pages

Typical Panel Categories for Restoration

When searching for relevant panels, look for these category descriptions:

- Building restoration and remediation services
- Water damage restoration
- Mould remediation and assessment
- Fire and smoke damage restoration
- Emergency building services
- Facilities maintenance — specialist trades
- Environmental remediation
- Asbestos and hazardous materials removal (separate licensing required)

Chapter 2: Required IICRC Certifications

Why Panels Ask for IICRC Certification

Government procurement officers evaluate contractors on documented competency. IICRC (Institute of Inspection Cleaning and Restoration Certification) is a globally recognised standard for restoration qualifications, and many Australian government tender specifications for restoration work reference IICRC standards and certifications.

One important distinction before you plan your training: IICRC certification itself (WRT, ASD, FSRT and so on) is obtained only through schools and examinations approved by the IICRC. CARSI is an IICRC CEC Accredited provider. CARSI courses do not grant IICRC certification.

What procurement officers look for:

- IICRC certification numbers for key personnel
- Evidence of continuing education (CECs)
- Alignment with IICRC S500 (water), S520 (mould), and S300 (carpet) standards
- Current certification status (not expired)

Essential Certifications by Service Type

TIER 1: FOUNDATION (MINIMUM FOR ANY PANEL APPLICATION)

Certification	Code	Why It's Required
Water Damage Restoration Technician	WRT	Foundation for all water damage work. Commonly referenced in government restoration panel specifications.
Applied Structural Drying Technician	ASD	Demonstrates advanced drying science knowledge. Required for complex structural drying projects.

TIER 2: SPECIALIST (BROADENS PANEL ELIGIBILITY)

Certification	Code	Why It's Required
Carpet Repair & Reinstallation Technician	RRT	Required for soft flooring restoration in government buildings (schools, offices, aged care).
Odor Control Technician	OCT	Specialist skill for fire/smoke damage, sewage events, and environmental odour issues.
Commercial Carpet Maintenance Technician	CCMT	High-volume commercial maintenance for government office buildings.

TIER 3: ADVANCED (PREMIUM PANEL POSITIONS)

Certification	Code	Why It's Required
Mould Remediation (aligned to IICRC S520)	—	Critical for health-sensitive environments (hospitals, schools, aged care). Some states require specific mould licences.
Fire and Smoke Damage Restoration Technician	FSRT	Required for fire damage panels. Often separate from water damage panels.

CEC (Continuing Education Credit) Requirements

IICRC certifications require ongoing education to maintain active status:

- **14 CECs every four years** for a certification; Master and Inspector certifications need 14 CECs every two years (IICRC Australia FAQ, iicrc.org/ausfaqs)

- CECs must be earned through CE providers approved by the IICRC
- CARSI is an IICRC CEC Accredited provider
- Government panels may audit your CEC records — keep them current

Pro tip: A CARSI yearly membership ($795 AUD/year, per learner) provides access to all published CARSI courses, and team plans are available for crews and larger businesses — see carsi.com.au/pricing for current options. Online, self-paced training also avoids the travel and downtime costs of face-to-face sessions.

Chapter 3: WHS Compliance Checklist

Work Health and Safety Requirements

Government agencies are bound by the *Work Health and Safety Act 2011* (harmonised across most states) and take WHS compliance extremely seriously. Your panel application will be assessed against these requirements.

Documentation Required

1. WHS MANAGEMENT SYSTEM

- ☐ Written WHS policy signed by a director or principal
- ☐ WHS management plan specific to restoration work
- ☐ Hazard identification and risk assessment procedures
- ☐ Incident reporting and investigation procedures
- ☐ Emergency response plan
- ☐ Worker consultation and communication procedures

2. SAFE WORK METHOD STATEMENTS (SWMS)

You will need SWMS for every high-risk construction work activity. For restoration, this typically includes:

- ☐ Working at heights (above 2 metres)
- ☐ Working in confined spaces (subfloor, ceiling cavities, tanks)
- ☐ Handling hazardous chemicals (antimicrobials, biocides, sealants)
- ☐ Asbestos awareness and management (pre-2000 buildings)
- ☐ Electrical safety (working near water and electrical systems)
- ☐ Manual handling (equipment, extraction, furniture relocation)
- ☐ Hot works (thermal fogging, welding during fire restoration)
- ☐ Working near traffic or public areas

3. INSURANCE CERTIFICATES

Insurance Type	Minimum Cover	Notes
Public liability	Set by each panel (check)	Read the amount in each tender
Professional indemnity	Set by each panel (check)	Required for assessment/consulting work
Workers' compensation	State statutory requirements	Must be current for all workers
Motor vehicle	Comprehensive fleet cover	Required if vehicles enter government sites
Pollution liability	Set by each panel (check)	Increasingly required for mould/hazmat work

4. PERSONNEL QUALIFICATIONS

- ☐ IICRC certifications for all technicians (not just the business owner)
- ☐ White Card (General Construction Induction) for all site workers
- ☐ Working with Children Check (for school/childcare facility work)
- ☐ National Police Check (for sensitive sites — defence, justice, healthcare)
- ☐ First Aid Certificate (current, within 3 years)
- ☐ Asbestos Awareness training (mandatory for pre-2000 buildings)
- ☐ Confined Space Entry certification (where applicable)

5. ENVIRONMENTAL MANAGEMENT

- ☐ Waste management plan (restoration generates significant waste)
- ☐ Hazardous waste disposal procedures and licensed waste contractor details
- ☐ Environmental incident response procedure
- ☐ Water usage and discharge plan (relevant for flood restoration)

State-Specific Requirements

State	Additional Requirement
NSW	SafeWork NSW notification for certain high-risk work
VIC	WorkSafe Victoria registration; EPA licence for certain waste
QLD	QBCC licence for building work above $3,300
WA	Building Services Board registration
SA	SafeWork SA notification requirements
TAS	WorkSafe Tasmania registration

Chapter 4: The Application Process

Step 1: Register on Procurement Platforms

Create accounts on all relevant platforms (see Chapter 1). Complete your supplier profile thoroughly — procurement officers use these profiles to shortlist candidates.

Profile essentials:

- ABN and company registration details
- Capability statement (see below)
- Insurance certificates of currency
- IICRC certification evidence
- WHS management system summary
- Reference letters from previous clients

Step 2: Prepare Your Capability Statement

A capability statement is a 2–4 page document that summarises your company's qualifications. Government procurement officers review hundreds of these — make yours scannable and evidence-based.

Structure:

1. **Company overview** — Who you are, years in operation, locations serviced
2. **Core services** — List each restoration service with IICRC standard alignment
3. **Personnel qualifications** — Table of staff, their IICRC certifications, and CEC status
4. **Equipment inventory** — Major equipment categories (extractors, dehumidifiers, air scrubbers, moisture meters, thermal imaging cameras)
5. **Insurance summary** — Policy types, coverage amounts, insurer names
6. **WHS credentials** — WHS management system accreditation, incident record, safety awards
7. **Past performance** — 3–5 relevant project summaries (scope, value, outcome, client reference)
8. **Capacity** — Response time commitment, geographic coverage, staffing levels

Step 3: Monitor and Respond to Panel Openings

AusTender search strategy:

1. Log in to austender.gov.au
2. Set up saved searches for keywords: "restoration", "remediation", "water damage", "mould", "cleaning and restoration", "building maintenance"
3. Filter by category: "Building Construction and Support and Maintenance and Repair Services"
4. Enable email notifications for new opportunities

Response tips:

- Answer every question in the evaluation criteria — skipping questions results in automatic exclusion
- Provide evidence, not assertions ("Our team holds 12 active IICRC certifications" vs "We are highly qualified")

- Include case studies that match the panel's scope
- Submit before the deadline — late submissions are never accepted

Step 4: Panel Interview / Presentation

Some government panels require a presentation or interview. Prepare for:

- **Technical questions** — "Describe your approach to a Category 3 water loss in an occupied school"
- **WHS scenarios** — "How would you manage asbestos discovery during a restoration project?"
- **Capacity questions** — "Can you mobilise a team to a regional site within 24 hours?"
- **Quality assurance** — "How do you document moisture readings and drying progress?"

Pro tip: Bring your IICRC credentials, CEC records, and equipment inventory as printed supporting documents.

Chapter 5: Worked Example — What Panel Readiness Looks Like

The scenario below is illustrative. It is a composite example of the panel-readiness path, not an account of a specific CARSI client, and the figures are indicative only.

An Illustrative Mid-Sized Restoration Business

Company profile:

- Location: South-East Queensland
- Staff: 14 (8 technicians, 3 project managers, 3 admin)
- Established restoration business with strong commercial and insurance work

The challenge:

The business has been operating for several years with steady commercial and insurance work but zero government contracts. The owner knows government panels offer stable, high-value work but earlier applications went nowhere — the experience was there, but the documented evidence wasn't.

What a panel-ready business changes:

1. **Closes the certification gap** — Technicians who need IICRC certification book it through a school and examination approved by the IICRC. Everyone who already holds a certification keeps it current with CARSI courses the IICRC has approved for CEC hours, so every credential on the capability statement is active and auditable.
1. **Builds a WHS management system** — Engages a WHS consultant to formalise existing procedures into a documented management system, with SWMS for all high-risk activities.
1. **Upgrades insurance** — Increases public liability to the amount the panel requires and adds pollution liability cover for mould and hazmat work.
1. **Creates a professional capability statement** — A concise document with an IICRC certification table, equipment inventory, and project case studies with measurable outcomes.

1. **Applies systematically** — Registers on AusTender, QTenders, and local council procurement platforms. Sets up keyword alerts. Responds to every relevant panel opening.

Why this works:

Panel evaluators score documented evidence, not assertions. A certification table where every entry is verifiable, current, and backed by CEC records answers the competency criteria directly — which is precisely where under-documented applications fall down. Businesses that make these changes put themselves in a position to compete credibly for state and council panel positions, and the online, self-paced format of CARSI training means the upskilling happens without pulling technicians off billable work.

Chapter 6: Quick-Start Action Plan

Your 90-Day Path to Panel Readiness

Week	Action	Resources
1–2	Audit current certifications. Identify gaps.	CARSI pathway tool at carsi.com.au/pathways
3–6	Book IICRC certification (WRT minimum) through a school approved by the IICRC. Keep existing credentials current with CARSI courses the IICRC has approved.	iicrc.org + carsi.com.au
5–6	Review and upgrade insurance policies.	Your insurance broker
5–8	Build or formalise WHS management system. Complete all SWMS.	WHS consultant or SafeWork Australia templates
7–8	Prepare capability statement. Gather project case studies and references.	See the structure in Chapter 4
9–10	Register on all relevant procurement platforms. Set up keyword alerts.	See Chapter 1 platform list
11–12	Submit first panel application.	—
Ongoing	Monitor alerts. Apply to every relevant panel. Maintain CEC currency with CARSI courses the IICRC has approved.	CARSI CEC tracking

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Key Takeaways

1. **Government panels are accessible** — They're not reserved for large companies. Many panels specifically target SMEs and regional businesses.
2. **IICRC certifications are the entry ticket** — Without documented competency, your application is unlikely to succeed regardless of your experience.
3. **WHS compliance is non-negotiable** — Government agencies audit WHS records. Your system must be documented, current, and evidence-based.

4. **Start with your state** — Local and state government panels are generally easier to access than federal panels. Build your track record locally first.
5. **Online CEC training removes a major barrier** — CARSI's 24/7, self-paced courses that the IICRC has approved mean your team can keep certifications current without losing billable days.

Next Steps

Ready to get panel-ready?

1. **Assess your team's certifications** — Visit carsi.com.au/pathways to see which IICRC credentials your target panels call for
2. **Start with WRT** — Water Damage Restoration Technician is the foundation credential for government restoration panel work, obtained through a school and examination approved by the IICRC
3. **Keep your CECs current with CARSI courses the IICRC has approved** — Individual and team membership options are at carsi.com.au/pricing

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Appendix: Useful Links

Resource	URL
AusTender (Federal)	austender.gov.au
NSW eTendering	tenders.nsw.gov.au
Buying for Victoria	buying.vic.gov.au
QLD QTenders	qtenders.epw.qld.gov.au
WA Tenders	tenders.wa.gov.au
SafeWork Australia — SWMS Templates	safeworkaustralia.gov.au
IICRC Standards	iicrc.org/standards
CARSI Courses	carsi.com.au
CARSI Pathways	carsi.com.au/pathways

Last updated: 2026-07-09 Lead magnet owner: CARSI Marketing Linear issue: GP-199 Format: Designed for PDF conversion (A4, ~15 pages)